

A Better Society, Thanks to Technology

With a rise in social entrepreneurship, technology is beginning to help across several areas of societal development—be it providing information, services and education to rural India, detecting and curtailing epidemics, or fighting against eve-teasing. Here is a quick round-up of such tech solutions with a social spin—to help you understand what motivates these entrepreneurs and think about whether you would like to follow a similar path



Entire team of Real-Time Biosurveillance Program (RTBP)

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When floods ravaged the state of Uttarakhand, technology buzzed to the rescue. Vodafone India set up help desks from where people could call the government helpline numbers or their family. Not just the helplines but other Vodafone users in the region also got a free emergency top-up for their prepaid numbers, so that they were not stranded. Helplines and mobile charging units were also set up in the local help pads, allowing free calls by the rescued to their families.

Even as Vodafone demonstrated timely use of tech infrastructure, Google came to the rescue by conjuring up apps to help rescue teams. It launched

a crisis map of the flood-hit state to provide quick information on places affected, relief centres, medical centres and road closures. It also activated a Person Finder tool—a Web-based application that helps feed names of people you are looking for, as well as share information about somebody who has been found or rescued. When there is a match for a person being searched for, it is displayed.

These are typical examples of how technology comes to the aid of society in times of need. At other times and places, other situations have motivated other technologists and entrepreneurs to develop solutions with social spins. These are the silent tech heroes of this world. Some have risen to a celebrity status, others do their job quietly but continue to benefit society and be satisfied with the outcome. Some com-

panies develop such solutions as part of their corporate social responsibility (CSR) charters, and some technologists do it for personal satisfaction, while other entrepreneurs manage to implement such socially-beneficial solutions with a profitable business plan—although this calls for a fine balancing of reach and pricing.

In this story, we quickly scan such technological solutions that have a social spin, from the perspective of motivation, technology and business.

Social media platform to connect charities and volunteers

Social tag: Charity

Tech tag: SAP HANA, social media, cloud, mobile

SAP's Charitra stands for 'Charity Transformation.' It was designed in 90 days as a social network, and presently connects social causes posted by NGOs or individuals with potential volunteers or donors, so that they can contribute their time, skill or materials for the cause. It also helps NGOs, CSRs and others to organise their relief efforts and engage with other organisations in the relief efforts.

"Charity is becoming an essential element in people's lives and individuals are more conscious about being charitable. Not knowing how to channel donations is a key issue for people wanting to participate in acts of charity. Social media is an increasingly effective strategy for all industries to connect with external stakeholders and in no way an impediment for charities to engage with. It has the power to personalise communication, establishing